

Soccer

Note: For the purposes of this content, the Sports Performance Coach should focus on using the OPT™ Model with all players. Although the demands of soccer positions vary, the fundamental principles of integrated training will improve all positions' stability, strength, and power. The prevalence of lower-extremity injuries in soccer is a cause of concern for all sports coaches (Junge & Dvorak, 2004). Corrective exercise programs have shown promise in reducing certain injuries in a variety of demographics (Campa et al., 2019; Grooms et al., 2013; Mozafaripour et al., 2022).

If an individual needs to modify the model based on the athlete's needs, then it is very appropriate to do so based on the assessment process, the position's needs, and the goals set for the athlete. The Sports Performance Coach will focus on "off-field" performance training to decrease injury and increase "on-field" performance.

Demands of the Sport	
General Information	Activity Information
• Less than 2% of the total distance covered during a game is with the ball. • The aerobic energy system predominates and is responsible for as much as 98% of the energy utilized (Bangsbo et al., 1991). • Matches are typically decided at the highest speeds, with the ATP-PCr and glycolytic systems being dominant.	• Distance covered by a player in a match: 10–13 km (Mohr et al., 2003) • 1,000–1,200 changes in locomotion patterns occur during a match; there is approximately one change every 4.5 seconds of play (Bangsbo, 1994b) • Activity pattern defined by running intensity/speed: ○ Standing: 17.1% of total activity ○ Walking: 40.4% of total activity ○ Low-intensity running: 35.1% of total activity ○ High-intensity running: 8.1% of total activity ○ Sprinting: 0.7% of total activity • Average sprint: 15 meters • Average one sprint every 90 seconds • Variations in all demands are position-specific and vary between matches • Higher-level players will cover more ground and spend more time at higher intensities than lower-level players (Gore, 2000) • Distance covered in the second half of play is typically less than that covered in the first half of play (Gore, 2000)

Suggested Assessments for Soccer

Assessment Type	Assessment Method
Transitional postural assessments	• Overhead squat test • Single-leg squat test • Split squat • Star excursion balance test
Mobility assessments (if needed)	• Foot and ankle testing • Lumbo-pelvic-hip complex testing • Shoulder and spine testing
Dynamic movement assessments	• Drop jump • Shark skill test • Davies test • Triple cross-over hop test
Aerobic test: Choose one of the following	• 12-minute run test • 1.5-mile run test • Beep test • Yo-yo intermittent recovery test
Anaerobic test	• 300-yard shuttle run
Muscular endurance assessments	• Push-up test • Pull-up test • Curl-up test
Muscular strength assessments	• 1–5 RM bench press • 1–5 RM squat • Nordic hamstring lower test
Power assessments	• Vertical jump test (double-leg) • Vertical jump test (single-leg) • Rotational medicine ball throw test (left and right) • Medicine ball soccer throw
Speed assessments	• 40-yard sprint test • 10-yard sprint test
Agility assessments	• LEFT (lower-extremity functional) test • T-test • 5–10–5 (pro agility test)

Assessment & Program Strategies: Soccer



Sample Off-Season Weekly OPT Soccer Schedule

Month 1: 2 days/week

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
OPT Phase	Corrective	OFF	OFF	Corrective	OFF	OFF	OFF

Month 2: 2 days/week

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
OPT Phase	Stabilization Endurance	OFF	OFF	Stabilization Endurance	OFF	OFF	OFF

Month 3: 4 days/week

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
OPT Phase	Strength Endurance		OFF	Strength Endurance		OFF	OFF
Other	Conditioning				Conditioning		

Month 4: 4 days/week

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
OPT Phase	Power		OFF	Power		OFF	OFF
Other	Conditioning				Conditioning		

Month 5: 5 days/week

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
OPT Phase	Stabilization Endurance		Stabilization Endurance		Stabilization Endurance	OFF	OFF
Other	Conditioning			Conditioning			

Month 6: 5 days/week

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
OPT Phase	Strength Endurance	OFF	Strength Endurance	OFF	Strength Endurance	OFF	OFF
Other	Conditioning			Conditioning			

Month 7: 5 days/week

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
OPT Phase	Strength Endurance		Stabilization Endurance	Power	OFF	OFF	Other
Other	Conditioning		Conditioning				

Assessment & Program Strategies: Soccer



Sample Off-Season OPT Soccer Programs *Corrective Exercise Training*

INHIBIT				Sets	Reps	Time
Myofascial Rolling						
Calves				1		30 sec
Tensor fascia latae				1		30 sec
IT band				1		30 sec
Adductors						
LENGTHEN				Sets	Reps	Time
Gastrocnemius stretch				1		30 sec
Soleus stretch				1		30 sec
Supine biceps femoris stretch				1		30 sec
Kneeling hip flexor stretch				1		30 sec
Standing adductor stretch				1		30 sec
ACTIVATE		Sets	Reps	Tempo	Intensity	Rest
Single-leg calf raise		2	12	4/2/1		0 sec
Single-leg hip adduction		2	12	4/2/1		0 sec
Single-leg hip abduction: Gluteus medius		2	12	4/2/1		0 sec
Floor bridge		2	12	4/2/1		90 sec
INTEGRATE		Sets	Reps	Tempo	Intensity	Rest
Cable squat to row		2	12	4/2/1	60%	0 sec

Assessment & Program Strategies: Soccer

Phase I: Stabilization Endurance Training

WARM-UP			Sets	Reps	Time	
Myofascial Rolling						
Tensor fascia latae			1			30 sec
Piriformis			1			30 sec
Static Stretching						
Gastrocnemius stretch			1			30 sec
Kneeling hip flexor stretch			1			30 sec
Standing biceps femoris stretch			1			30 sec
Dynamic Stretching		Sets	Reps	Tempo		
Lunge with rotation		1	10	Moderate	0 sec	
MB woodchop		1	10	Moderate	0 sec	
CORE AND BALANCE		Sets	Reps	Tempo	Rest	
Side iso-ab		1	15	4/2/1	0 sec	
Floor bridge: Single-leg		1	15	4/2/1	0 sec	
Single-leg balance reach		1	15	4/2/1	60 sec	
PLYOMETRICS		Sets	Reps	Tempo	Rest	
Squat jump with stabilization		1	6	Hold landing	60 sec	
SPEED/AGILITY/QUICKNESS		Sets	Reps	Tempo	Rest	
Speed ladder: Six exercises		2			60 sec	
RESISTANCE		Sets	Reps	Tempo	Intensity	Rest
Total body	Lunge, balance to overhead press: Single-arm	1	20	4/2/1	60%	0 sec
Chest	Cable chest press: Alternate-arm	1	20	4/2/1	60%	0 sec
Back	SL bent-over DB cobra	1	20	4/2/1	60%	0 sec
Shoulders	Done in total-body exercise					
Biceps	Single-leg DB curl: Alternate-arm	1	20	4/2/1	60%	0 sec
Triceps	SL triceps extension	1	20	4/2/1	60%	0 sec
Legs	Single-leg squat	1	20	4/2/1	60%	90 sec
COOL-DOWN						
Myofascial rolling and static stretching						

Assessment & Program Strategies: Soccer

Phase 2: Strength Endurance Training

WARM-UP		Sets	Reps	Time
Myofascial Rolling				
IT band		1		30 sec
Piriformis		1		30 sec
Calves		1		30 sec
Active Stretching				
Standing adductor stretch		1	10	
Standing hip flexor stretch		1	10	
Standing pec stretch		1	10	
Dynamic Stretching		Sets	Reps	Tempo
Multiplanar lunge with MB woodchop		1	10	Moderately fast
Squat to overhead reach		1	10	Moderately fast
CORE AND BALANCE		Sets	Reps	Tempo
Knee-ups		2	12	1/1/1
Back extension with rotation		2	12	1/1/1
Single-leg squat touchdown		2	12	1/1/1
PLYOMETRICS		Sets	Reps	Tempo
Butt kicks		2	8	Repeating
Cone hops: Side to side		2	8	Repeating
SPEED/AGILITY/QUICKNESS		Sets	Reps	Tempo
Speed ladder: Six exercises		2		
LEFT test		2		
RESISTANCE		Sets	Reps	Tempo
Total body	Optional			
Chest	Incline DB press	2	12	2/0/2
	Cable chest press: SA		8	4/2/1
Back	Seated lat pull-down	2	12	2/0/2
	Single-leg cable row		8	4/2/1
Shoulders	Seated overhead DB press		12	2/0/2
	SL scaption raise		8	4/2/1
Legs	Barbell squats	3	12	2/0/2
	Side lunge to balance		8	4/2/1
COOL-DOWN				
Myofascial rolling and static stretching				

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WARM-UP				Sets	Reps	Time
Myofascial Rolling						
Calves				1		30 sec
Tensor fascia latae				1		30 sec
Adductors				1		30 sec
Dynamic Warm-up (Some athletes may still require static stretching prior to dynamic warm-up.)						
Lateral tube walking				1	10	0 sec
Prisoner squats				1	10	0 sec
Lunge with rotation				1	10	0 sec
Leg swings: Front to back				1	10	0 sec
Push-up with rotation				1	10	0 sec
Scorpion				1	10	0 sec
Multiplanar hop to stabilization				1	10	60 sec
CORE AND BALANCE			Sets	Reps	Tempo	Rest
No CORE AND BALANCE (incorporated into dynamic warm-up and resistance workout)						
PLYOMETRICS			Sets	Reps	Tempo	Rest
No PLYOMETRICS (incorporated into dynamic warm-up and resistance workout)						
SPEED/AGILITY/QUICKNESS			Sets	Reps	Tempo	Rest
Speed ladder: Eight exercises			1			60 sec
Box drill			4			30 sec
RESISTANCE		Sets	Reps	Tempo	Intensity	Rest
Total body	Lunge, curl to overhead press	3	5	1/0/1	85%	0 sec
	Overhead MB throw		10	Explosive	2% of BW	2 min
Chest	DB chest press	3	5	1/0/1	85%	0 sec
	Rotational chest press		10	Explosive	2% of BW	2 min
Back	Seated lat pull-down	3	5	1/0/1	85%	0 sec
	MB soccer throw		10	Explosive	2% of BW	2 min
Shoulders	Done in total-body exercises					
Legs	Barbell squat	3	5	1/0/1	85%	0 sec
	Power step-ups		10	Explosive	2% of BW	2 min
COOL-DOWN						
Myofascial rolling and static stretching						

Preseason Goals and Considerations for Soccer

Goals	Considerations
• Correct impaired movement patterns based on results of preseason assessments • Maintain: ○ Physical health (decreases the chance of injury for participation in practice and games, and optimal performance within such activities) ○ Range of motion, joint stability, and muscle strength and endurance ○ Cardiorespiratory endurance (aerobic/anaerobic) ○ Total-body stabilization, strength, and power	• A systematic preseason plan that transitions the athlete from performance enhancement to injury prevention and maintenance of off-season gains will be developed. This transition should be implemented with the consideration that the athlete's sport participation level is increasing dramatically from what they have become used to in the off-season. • Proper recovery and conditioning, during this time of increased activity, will be applied. • Exercise volume of injury prevention, and performance training based on the athlete's increased activity level, will be considered.

Sample Preseason OPT Soccer Plan (August)

		JAN-JUL	AUG	SEP-DEC
		Off-Season	Pre-Season (1)	In-Season
Level	Phase			
Corrective				
Stabilization	1		X	
Strength	2		X	
	3			
	4			
Power	5			
	6			

Assessment & Program Strategies: Soccer



Sample Preseason Weekly OPT Soccer Schedule

Month 1

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
OPT Phase	Stabilization Endurance	OFF	Strength Endurance	OFF	Corrective	OFF	Corrective
Other	Game						

Sample Preseason OPT Soccer Programs

Corrective Exercise Training

INHIBIT				Sets	Reps	Time	
Myofascial Rolling							
Quads				1		30 sec	
Tensor fascia latae				1		30 sec	
IT band				1		30 sec	
Adductors				1		30 sec	
LENGTHEN				Sets	Reps	Time	
Gastrocnemius stretch				1		30 sec	
Supine piriformis stretch				1		30 sec	
Supine biceps femoris stretch				1		30 sec	
Kneeling hip flexor stretch				1		30 sec	
Standing adductor stretch				1		30 sec	
ACTIVATE			Sets	Reps	Tempo	Intensity	Rest
Side-lying hip adduction			3	10	4/2/1		0 sec
Single-leg hip abduction: Gluteus medius			3	10	4/2/1		60 sec
INTEGRATE			Sets	Reps	Tempo	Intensity	Rest
Total body	Side lunge to overhead press: Single-arm		3	10	4/2/1	60%	60 sec

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Phase I: Stabilization Endurance Training

WARM-UP				Sets	Reps	Time
Myofascial Rolling						
Tensor fascia latae				1		30 sec
IT band				1		30 sec
Piriformis				1		30 sec
Static Stretching						
Gastrocnemius stretch				1		30 sec
Kneeling hip flexor stretch				1		30 sec
Standing hip flexor stretch				1		30 sec
Standing adductor stretch				1		30 sec
Floor lat stretch				1		30 sec
Dynamic Stretching			Sets	Reps	Tempo	
Lunge with rotation			1	10	Moderate	0 sec
MB woodchop			1	10	Moderate	0 sec
CORE AND BALANCE			Sets	Reps		Tempo
Quadruped arm opposite-leg raise			2	15	4/2/1	0 sec
Floor bridge: Alternate-leg			2	15	4/2/1	0 sec
Single-leg lift and chop			2	15	4/2/1	60 sec
PLYOMETRICS			Sets	Reps	Tempo	Rest
No PLYOMETRICS due to increased activity						
SPEED/AGILITY/QUICKNESS			Sets	Reps	Distance	Rest
No SAQ due to increased activity						
RESISTANCE		Sets	Reps	Tempo	Intensity	Rest
Total body	Optional					
Chest	SL suspension chest press	2	15	4/2/1	65%	0 sec
Back	SL suspension row	2	15	4/2/1	65%	0 sec
Shoulders	Bent-over row DB combo I	2	15	4/2/1	65%	0 sec
Legs	Single-leg Romanian deadlift	2	15	4/2/1	65%	90 sec
COOL-DOWN						
Myofascial rolling and static stretching						

In-Season Goals and Considerations for Soccer

Goals	Considerations
- Maintain: - Range of motion, joint stability, and muscle strength and endurance - Cardiorespiratory endurance (aerobic/anaerobic) - Total-body stabilization, strength, and power - Establish a communication process for monitoring in-season maintenance, and a plan that works based on what the athlete needs, wants, and will have the capacity to do focusing on their job playing soccer	- Assessments and testing, to ensure program considerations are being made to prevent overuse injuries and maintain performance levels, will be performed. - Impaired movement patterns with exercise strategies being implemented will be attended to. - Additional conditioning, for athletes who may not get the same type of on-field game minutes as others, will be considered. - A systematic in-season maintenance plan will be developed that allows the athlete to minimize a decrease in fitness and chances of injury over a long season with repetitive sport movement patterns. - The exercise volume of injury prevention, and performance training based on the athlete's increased travel and activity level, will be considered.

In-Season OPT Soccer Plan (September–December)

Level	Phase	JAN–JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV	DEC
		Off-Season	Pre-Season	In-Season (1)	In-Season (2)	In-Season (3)	In-Season (4)
Corrective				X	X	X	X
Stabilization	1			X	X	X	X
Strength	2			X	X	X	X
	3						
	4						
Power	5						
	6						

Sample In-Season Weekly OPT Soccer Schedule

Any Month

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
OPT Phase	Corrective	Strength Endurance	OFF	Corrective	Corrective	OFF	
Other					Game		Game

Sample In-Season OPT Soccer Program

Corrective Exercise Training

INHIBIT			Sets	Reps	Time	
Myofascial Rolling						
Quads			1		30 sec	
Tensor fascia latae			1		30 sec	
IT band			1		30 sec	
Adductors			1		30 sec	
LENGTHEN			Sets	Reps	Time	
Gastrocnemius stretch			1		30 sec	
Supine piriformis stretch			1		30sec	
Supine biceps femoris stretch			1		30 sec	
Kneeling hip flexor stretch			1		30 sec	
Standing adductor stretch			1		30 sec	
ACTIVATE		Sets	Reps	Tempo	Intensity	Rest
Single-leg hip adduction		2	12	4/2/1		0 sec
Single-leg calf raise		2	12	4/2/1		60 sec
INTEGRATE		Sets	Reps	Tempo	Intensity	Rest
Total body	Side step-up, balance to overhead press	2	12	4/2/1	60%	60 sec

Assessment & Program Strategies: Soccer



Phase I: Stabilization Endurance Training

WARM-UP			Sets	Reps	Time	
Myofascial Rolling						
Tensor fascia latae			1		30 sec	
IT band			1		30 sec	
Piriformis			1		30 sec	
Static Stretching						
Gastrocnemius stretch			1		30 sec	
Kneeling hip flexor stretch			1		30 sec	
Supine biceps femoris stretch			1		30 sec	
Dynamic Stretching		Sets	Reps	Tempo		
Lunge with rotation		1	10	Moderate	0 sec	
MB woodchop		1	10	Moderate	0 sec	
CORE AND BALANCE		Sets	Reps	Tempo	Rest	
Prone iso-ab		2	15	4/2/1	0 sec	
Standing cable iso-rotation		2	15	4/2/1	0 sec	
Single-leg rotation		2	15	4/2/1	60 sec	
PLYOMETRICS, SPEED/AGILITY/QUICKNESS		Sets	Reps	Tempo	Rest	
Box jump-up with stabilization		2	6	Controlled	60 sec	
SPEED/AGILITY/QUICKNESS						
No SAQ due to increased activity						
RESISTANCE		Sets	Reps	Tempo	Intensity	Rest
Total body	Optional					
Chest	SL suspension chest press	2	15	4/2/1	65%	0 sec
Back	Single-leg cable row: Single-arm	2	15	4/2/1	65%	0 sec
Shoulders	Suspension Y's	2	15	4/2/1	65%	0 sec
Legs	SL squat	2	15	4/2/1	65%	90 sec
COOL-DOWN						
Myofascial rolling and static stretching						

Assessment & Program Strategies: Soccer



Phase 2: Strength Endurance Training

WARM-UP			Sets	Reps	Time	
Myofascial Rolling						
IT band			1		30 sec	
Piriformis			1		30 sec	
Thoracic spine			1		30 sec	
Active Stretching						
Gastrocnemius			1	10		
Standing hip flexor stretch			1	10		
Standing adductor stretch			1	10		
Dynamic Stretching		Sets	Reps	Tempo	Rest	
Multiplanar lunge with reach		1	10	Moderately fast	0 sec	
Squat to overhead reach		1	10	Moderately fast	0 sec	
CORE AND BALANCE						
Crunch with rotation		2	12	1/1/1	0 sec	
Cable rotations		2	12	1/1/1	0 sec	
Side step-up to balance		2	12	1/1/1	60 sec	
PLYOMETRICS		Sets	Reps	Tempo	Rest	
No PLYOMETRICS because of increased activity						
SPEED/AGILITY/QUICKNESS		Sets	Reps	Distance	Rest	
No SAQ because of on-field conditioning						
RESISTANCE		Sets	Reps	Tempo	Intensity	Rest
Total body	Optional					
Chest	Incline DB press	3	10	2/0/2	75%	0 sec
	Suspension push-up: Feet in straps		10	4/2/1	60%	
Back	Seated cable row	3	10	2/0/2	75%	0 sec
	SL lat pull-down		10	4/2/1	60%	
Shoulders	Seated DB scaption	3	10	2/0/2	75%	0 sec
	SL SA DB press		10	4/2/1	60%	
Legs	Deadlift	3	10	2/0/2	75%	60 sec
	Reverse lunge to balance		10	4/2/1	60%	
COOL-DOWN						
Myofascial rolling and static stretching						